

DHARMENDRA PRADHAN

Union Minister of Education, and Skill Development & Entrepreneurship

ON EARLY CHILDHOOD EDUCATION

"For the first time in India, we have developed an institutional mechanism for early childhood education—for children aged three to six"

ON LANGUAGES

"India's many languages are our strength. The CBSE recently gave school administrators the option of [allowing instruction in an Indian language]"

ON RESEARCH

"The cabinet has approved the National Research Foundation. India is going to have a paradigm shift toward its basic science research"

"For the past 75 years, we have been a consuming economy [in terms of research]... today, when it comes to the digital economy, India is a bright spot. Our country's knowledge capacity runs the global digital ecosystem"

ON LOW ENROLMENT RATE IN HIGHER EDUCATION

"This is a major concern... In India, the working age group begins at 15. Economic and social compulsions pull children from disadvantaged backgrounds out of the higher education system"

ON TECHNOLOGICAL ADVANCEMENTS

"Just a year ago, no one knew what ChatGPT was. Science and technology are progressing so fast that I worry about how we will keep our students up to date"

ON IIT STUDENT SUICIDES

"IITs have a student-teacher ratio of 10:1. If a professor is in charge of just 10 students, they can help them 24x7. There are facilities too; counsellors as well. If such tragedies take place even in such conditions, we will have to take responsibility for it. Society, institutions and educational administrators, all of us have to make consistent efforts to prevent [suicides]"

ON NEP ROLLOUT

"The journey [so far] has been very satisfactory. With everybody's cooperation and criticism, we are on the right track and we will achieve our target in the near future"

was nothing. Things changed when the local government let go of control and the alumni took over. That's one of the first learnings—if there is too much control, too many regulations, something that crowds you, makes you claustrophobic... that's been happening in India, not just in the last few years but for a long time."

Another session saw a debate over the role of technology in education and the dangers of 'high-tech plagiarism', while also noting how students could benefit from innovative tools if used correctly. While educator and author Abha Adams raised concerns about erosion of core learning abilities due to technology, Coursera India's Prashasti Rastogi, talking about their AI-powered course builder, said: "What we did was to create an AI-powered course builder so that teachers can use [tools like ChatGPT] for inputs on the learning outcomes they want to deliver, and the software helps them build a course that is adaptive."

The last session of the day—'State of Mind: How to make studies stress-free'—saw participants discussing the crippling impact of mental stress. The issue has become all the more poignant in recent years given student suicides, especially in higher education institutes. Youth and parenting coach Rajat Soni highlighted the most common complaint among children—that adults didn't understand them—and said it's important that parents and educators try to consider their perspective. As the moderator put it, "There is something a lot of kids are talking about online. It's called 'take me seriously'. They say, 'When we come to you with our problems, we know you don't mean to be dismissive, but you're too busy to take us seriously'." ■

Aditya Mohan Wig

(Watch the full conclave at https://bit.ly/44U5hxU)